

BRIDGES



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TUNA

Cured Tuna with Dates
Young Onion

COMTÉ TART

24 Months Aged Comté in a Malted Barley Crust
Morels and Leeks

TROUT

Trout with Mussels and Swiss Chard
Beurre Blanc of White Wine, Bergamot, and Vermouth



One of the signature dishes at Bridges is the raw akami slices with dates. Curiosity about this unlikely pairing of tuna with dates is in fact one of the reasons that led me to book the restaurant. It is almost impossible not to associate tuna sashimi with Japanese cuisine, where tuna is among the most hailed sakana, and is nearly always paired with soy sauce. Here, however, the tuna is placed atop pitted dates and a touch of young onion confit. The bite is by no mean complex, nor does it carry the delicate precision of a refined tartelette that might open a fine dining tasting menu, but the flavor combination is so phenomenal, like nothing I have tasted before, yet somehow intimately comforting. The dark, sophisticated, caramel-like sweetness of the dates elevates the tuna's natural, subtle sweetness and its clean, faintly metallic notes. That metallic, iron-like quality, often subdued when paired with soy sauce, emerges here as a kind of protagonist under a spotlight, though played gently, its voice soft, almost soothing. Then, the young onion confit, a sweet and savory twist on its own, adds another layer. Slow cooking transforms its raw pungency into something mellow, rounded, and bridging, an element that quietly connects the fish and the dates. This dish is a brilliant invention, a true masterpiece, one that feels worthy of being documented in a culinary textbook.



The Comté tart may well be the single most famous dish at Bridges. Praise has been flowing into my ears, announcing it as the newest trend of Manhattan's dining scene. The star of the dish, Comté cheese aged for two years, is set in a crust made from a mixture of all-purpose flour and malted barley flour, then draped with morel mushrooms and a piece of leek. A finishing touch — perhaps a reduction of cream, butter, and mushroom — is poured over, giving the tart a velvety sheen. Originating in France's Jura Mountains, Comté is made from raw milk of Montbéliarde cows that graze on biodiverse mountain flora. Its flavor reads fruity, spicy, and deeply savory with age. Here, its texture resembles a delicate flan, a melting, almost fragile delicacy. While I appreciate the almost unbearable tenderness of the tart, the dish nevertheless reveals certain shortcomings. The morels lack the ideal suppleness due to undercooking, reading slightly lean on the palate, and the overall composition leans heavily toward salinity, resulting in a certain monotony.



Between a tuna main that would only echo its appetizer and a chicken dish that somehow enunciates mediocrity, the choice isn't difficult — we settle on the trout. It arrives in what first sounds to be a peasant arrangement. Half a dozen mussels resting atop the fillet. A closer look, however, reveals a quiet refinement. The mussels are large, plump, and glossy, each shell meticulously cleaned. The sauce holds a uniform sheen, almost unnaturally smooth reminiscent of a modern painting, or an emoji. Then, the taste surpasses the presentation. Begin with the mussels, we are struck by their richness and fullness, as if we had never quite tasted mussels before. Then the trout, likely cooked sous-vide, its texture hovers at that precise point between raw and tenderly done. Impossibly tender, heavenly soft. The dish resolves in the mouth through equilibrium of textures and flavors. The high acidity of the sauce against its velvety body, the earthy bitterness of Swiss chard, the trout's delicate nuttiness, the mussels' sweet umami. Taken together in a single bite, a symphony of buttery, oceanic umami is composed in the mouth.